This is the foundational difference between the Congress party and the BJP. To the Congress, every Indian is an integral part of the nation, irrespective of where they come from and who they are. Thus, in furthering an individual's needs and aspirations, the Congress feels it furthers national interest. That's why the Congress spends so much time listening to the people, in parliamentary processes, in inclusive governance and in republicanism (wherein we are obligated to listen to even the last person in the line). In contrast, the BJP has always held that it knows best—for the citizenry and the nation at large. That is why, rather than listening to India's constituent stakeholders and weaving their needs into a national plan, it has consistently tried to mould everything in its image—the people, ideas, states, public institutions, etc. Consequently, the Prime Minister has only imposed his and the Sangh Parivar's *mann ki baat* (personal reflections), ignoring *jann ki baat* (the people's voice). To ignore the people's voice is fundamentally contrary to the civilizational and constitutional idea of India. And it foretells a grave threat to India's social contract.

This has not been examined enough, but Bharat Jodo was also the ultimate confidence-building measure for political parties. The BJP has insidiously tried to undermine and circumscribe every other political party, partly because it is easier to gain and retain power by destroying the Opposition rather than on its own strength. This is when over 60 per cent of the population has voted for other parties. The BJP has broken parties—even its own allies—circumscribed legislators and suppressed the Opposition. This democratic regression is not just unconstitutional, but makes it even more difficult for the people of India to air their voices. But Rahul Gandhi took every party along in the Yatra, making it clear that it was their Yatra as much as his own. He gave them space, respected their agency and showed the people of India that each party was united in working for the common good. This was in stark contrast to the BJP's predatorial politics, and I believe that this bonhomie played a significant role in stitching together the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA).